

Compare Sources & Arguments

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Compare what two sources agree and disagree about, how they use evidence, and which argument is better supported.

2. What this skill means

When two sources address the same issue, compare them on the same dimension: claim, evidence, reasoning, purpose, or recommendation. A stronger argument is not the one you personally prefer; it is the one better supported by relevant evidence and sound reasoning.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not compare a claim from Source A with an unrelated detail from Source B. Do not choose the side you agree with before evaluating the support.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "What do both sources agree on?", "How do their recommendations differ?", "How does Source B challenge Source A?", or "Which argument is better supported and why?"

5. Repeatable method

- State Source A's claim and Source B's claim.
- List the evidence each source uses.
- Identify one point of agreement and one point of disagreement.
- Compare evidence quality and reasoning on the same issue.
- Choose the better-supported argument, not the more familiar opinion.

6. Worked example

Source A supports extending library hours permanently based on a student survey. Source B supports a shorter pilot, noting that the survey measured

preference but did not measure staffing cost or actual late-night attendance.

Question: How does Source B challenge Source A?

Reasoning: Source B does not deny that students want later hours; it argues that preference data alone are insufficient for a permanent schedule decision.

Best answer: It questions whether Source A's survey is sufficient evidence for a permanent change.

7. Common traps

- Choosing agreement because both sources mention the same topic.
- Comparing different kinds of evidence as if they answer the same question.
- Treating confidence or strong language as stronger support.

8. Diagnostic help

- If your answer could describe only one source, you may not actually be comparing them.
- If you picked a winner before listing each source's evidence, restart with the evidence.
- If both sources use data, ask which data more directly address the disputed claim.

9. Quick check

Source A wants a permanent weekend route; Source B wants a three-month pilot before deciding. Both agree Sunday workers have limited transport.

What do the sources agree on, and where do they differ?

Check yourself: They agree there is a transport-access problem; they differ on whether the evidence is strong enough for a permanent route now.